and dangerous. Spielberg agreed. With his initial support through The Planetary Society, Project META began.

META is an acronym for "Megachannel ExtraTerrestrial Assay." The single frequency of Drake's first system grew to 8.4 million. But each channel, each "station," we tune to has an exceptionally narrow frequency range. There are no known processes out among the stars and galaxies that can generate such sharp radio "lines." If we pick up anything falling into so narrow a channel, it must, we think, be a token of intelligence and technology.

What's more, the Earth turns—which means that any distant radio source will have a sizable apparent motion, like the rising and setting of the stars. Just as the steady tone of a car's horn dips as it drives by, so any authentic extraterrestrial radio source will exhibit a steady drift in frequency due to the Earth's rotation. In contrast, any source of radio interference at the Earth's surface will be rotating at the same speed as the META receiver. META's listening frequencies are continuously changed to compensate for the Earth's rotation, so that any narrow-band signals from the sky will always appear in a single channel. But any radio interference down here on Earth will give itself away by racing through adjacent channels.

The META radio telescope at Harvard, Massachusetts, is 26 meters (84 feet) in diameter. Each day, as the Earth rotates the telescope beneath the sky, a swath of stars narrower than the full moon is swept out and examined. Next day, it's an adjacent swath. Over a year, all of the northern sky and part of the southern is observed. An identical system, also sponsored by The Planetary Society, is in operation just outside Buenos Aires, Argentina, to examine the southern sky. So together the two META systems have been exploring the entire sky.

The radio telescope, gravitationally glued to the spinning Earth, looks at any given star for about two minutes. Then it's on to the next. 8.4 million channels sounds like a lot, but remember, each channel is very narrow. All of them together constitute only a few parts in 100,000 of the available radio spectrum. So we have to park our 8.4 million channels somewhere in the radio spectrum for each year of observation, near some frequency that an alien civilization,